

Networking and shared learning

***Shared learning—**
*a process
 of combining
 knowledge
 and experience
 across teams or
 organizations.*

The benefits of innovation networks don't happen by accident. Challenges to networking include: how to manage something you do not control; how to see system level effects and not self-interest; how to build shared risk-taking and avoid red tape; and how to avoid free riders who get benefits without contributing. The key issues in setting up a network are providing momentum for bringing the network together and clearly defining its purpose. The need for a network may be crisis-triggered or driven by a perception of opportunity. Third parties play key roles here: network brokers, gatekeepers, policy agents, and facilitators.

Networking also helps innovation by providing support for shared learning*, which allows for the status quo to be challenged, and for assumptions to undergo critical reflection from different perspectives. Shared learning provides a wider perspective, prevents insular ideas, and brings in new concepts. Shared experimentation reduces the perceived and actual cost and risk of trying new things, and shared experiences can provide support and open new lines of exploration.

